

Ban(ne)dwidth

Give a Digster surprise assignments, housekeeping missions involving tagging and organising the huge stock of magazines and three stories to finish in a week...but waning bandwidth is a little too much!

Access to the Internet for a Digster is tantamount to a continuous supply of oxygen. Writers often carry out vast amounts of research on the Internet before conducting interviews and trying out products for their stories and lack of bandwidth or even low bandwidth can seriously throw a spanner in the works.

Digsters who pride themselves at being the first ones to download the latest software every time found their style somewhat cramped this month as even browsing turned into a difficult proposition when our T1 lines went on the blink. It was worse for our Multimedia team who found themselves working on dial-up lines for the CD content of the March 2002 Digit issue. Add to that the fact that one of our cover stories required downloading and trying out several freeware before we shortlisted 30 of the best, and you'll see how much it hurt.

Our hardworking warriors were of

course up to the challenge of making do with less. Time management acquired a new meaning with people coming in at all odd hours to catch, nay trap bandwidth when fewer people were likely to be online. Every little trick in the trade was tried in order to get work done and not let schedules slip, punctuated ever so often with roars of frustration and uproars of anguish at the floundering Net connection.

Frayed nerves soon gave way to jokes as the folks at Digit refused to let the situation get the better of them. We overheard a writer telling another on a particularly slow day, "Let the page load and go home. It'll be complete by tomorrow afternoon." Nor was the entrepreneurial spirit lacking. We found this little note placed on a PC saying, "Put cash on table before you check mail or browse".

Meanwhile, our IT team got working on the problem. A new proxy server was set up and provided some respite in the interim. Well, now that things are back to normal, all those who live by the motto, "will work for bandwidth" are happy again. 



ILLUSTRATION: Mahes Benkar

Awww Hex!

There's a strange trend going on at Digit. Now we're not really superstitious, but of late our cover stories seem to be plaguing us in real life! When working on our January issue we had to 'virus proof' ourselves against a common cold virus that took a cue from our cover story and sought out the chinks in our armour.

Well, this month the jinx continued. If you're reading this bit then you know that one of our cover stories is 'The PC Troubleshooting Guide' by our Test Centre. Any story that involves the Test Centre doesn't see the light of day unless it's been thoroughly scrutinised. So what better way to serve up a comprehensive troubleshooting guide than to actually get your hands dirty fixing problems with your own PC? The only thing wrong here was that this wasn't included in the initial storyboard!

The first unlucky Digster was Hatim, who had to deal with successive processor malfunctions. The next to fall prey was one of our most heavily relied on designers, Shiva, who just couldn't keep his QuarkXPress from acting up. But not one to be easily frazzled, he confronted the problem by simply yelling out a warning, "Restarting!", to all those connected to his PC.

The jinx next struck the Multimedia team when Aichin's hard disk crashed. She is the lady who does the programming for the Digit Interactive CDs and her PC is where all the content is stored. The timing couldn't have been worse—just one day before the Mindware CD was to be sent for replication. Back-ups are a wonderful thing and came in handy. And the entire Multimedia team pitched in to redo all the lost work in one day, without missing a beat.

Well, as the saying goes, 'no rest for the wicked'. But here's a fun thought—maybe we should do a story on 'If personal robots were freeware'!